



# Chapter 3

## User personas

### Ages 9-12 · the puberty bridge

Bodies change, the door closes, and the internet quietly becomes the teacher. The co-play model breaks here: a pre-teen will not do a "body" game sitting next to a parent. India-segmented personas so Chapter 3 earns the trust the adults are starting to lose.

## The door closes.

Puberty arrives, and with it privacy. The child who happily played beside a parent at seven now wants the door shut. Bodies change, moods swing, comparison bites, and the questions get too embarrassing to ask a grown-up, so they get typed into a search bar instead. This is the chapter where parents go out of the loop and the internet steps in. Whatever fills that gap shapes everything after it.

### Four shifts from Chapter 2

| SHIFT                               | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                                              | WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO                                                             |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Co-play breaks</b>               | A pre-teen will not do a puberty or body game with a parent watching. Embarrassment is the gatekeeper now. | Make sensitive play private and solo; drop the "show a parent" beat on those nodes. |
| <b>The internet is the teacher</b>  | The questions they can't ask adults go to search, YouTube and friends, accurate or not.                    | Be the trusted, non-judgmental source: answer what they're too shy to ask.          |
| <b>Mind, not just body</b>          | Anxiety, comparison and self-esteem dips are now central, not a side note.                                 | Treat mental health as core content, with coping and where to turn.                 |
| <b>Neither childish nor preachy</b> | They reject baby aesthetics and lectures with equal speed.                                                 | A credible, slightly older voice; Lensy grows up a little here.                     |

Eight personas, three Indian segments, three roles. Each ends in design implications for the nine Chapter 3 games: Puberty Quest, Mind Matters, The Amazing Journey, Boundary Bot, Crossroads, Flip the Script, Norm Storm, Speak Up, and Defenders of the Body.

# Out of the loop, online, on their own.

The home segments mirror earlier chapters, but the adults are now reacting to a child who has pulled away, and the educators are the people delivering India's adolescent-health programmes into real taboo.

| PERSONA                 | ROLE     | SEGMENT                  | IN ONE LINE                                             | THE LEVER FOR DEPTH                                  |
|-------------------------|----------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rohit Mehra, 42</b>  | Parent   | Metro, hands-on dad      | Wants to talk to his son about respect and porn; can't. | Help the awkward adult start.                        |
| <b>Rekha Verma, 39</b>  | Parent   | Tier-2, joint family     | Her daughter's period is treated as a secret to hide.   | Inform without defying elders.                       |
| <b>Lakshmi Devi, 34</b> | Parent   | Low-income               | Periods mean missed school and a dropout risk.          | Equity: access, dignity, staying in school.          |
| <b>Aarav, 12</b>        | Child    | Metro                    | Withdrawn, gaming with voice chat, "be a man".          | Reach the boy before the feed does.                  |
| <b>Diya, 11</b>         | Child    | Tier-2                   | Just got her period; mortified to ask anyone.           | Private, accurate, shame-free.                       |
| <b>Priya, 12</b>        | Child    | Low-income               | The shared phone is her secret teacher.                 | Offline, in-language, dignity-first.                 |
| <b>Mr. Khanna, 38</b>   | Educator | School health teacher    | Must teach AEP into a wall of taboo.                    | Credible, parent-defensible, gendered-session ready. |
| <b>Asha, 24</b>         | Educator | RKSK / NGO peer educator | The non-parent the kids actually confide in.            | Near-peer trust; period poverty, dropout.            |

## THE ADULT OUT OF THE LOOP

## Rohit Mehra, 42

Architect · Bengaluru · hands-on father (wife travels) · son Aarav, 12

**"I know he's seen things online. I want to talk to him about respect, about what's real and what isn't. I just freeze."**

|           |                                                                 |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| HOME      | Nuclear; Rohit is the day-to-day parent, wife travels for work. |
| LANGUAGES | English; Aarav reads fluently and codes a little.               |
| DEVICES   | Aarav's own phone, a console with voice chat, his own room.     |
| SCHOOL    | Competitive private school; coaching has started.               |
| MONEY     | Comfortable; the problem is not money, it is words.             |

## What he wants

- A way in: a starting point for the talks he keeps freezing on.
- Aarav to get accurate, respectful information before the feed defines it.
- To support without surveilling; he doesn't want to read his son's chats.
- Help countering "be a man" and the stuff that says feelings are weakness.

## Why he'd bounce

- Anything that requires him to sit and co-play; Aarav would never.
- A childish tone Aarav will mock and close instantly.
- Spyware-style "monitor your child" features that break trust.

## NO GOOD TO ROHIT

A cute app he is meant to do with Aarav. His son would rather game; it will never be opened.

**A weeknight.** Aarav's door is shut, headset on, laughing at something Rohit can't see. He used to tell Rohit everything; now it is one-word answers. Rohit suspects he has seen porn, picked up "alpha" talk from gaming streams, and is bottling something up. Rohit is progressive and present, and still he cannot find a way in that doesn't make them both want to disappear.

## The bias he's up against

Not really his; it is the feed's, and the culture's. Aarav is absorbing that real men dominate and don't cry, that porn is how intimacy works, that emotions are for the weak.

~~Real men don't show feelings.~~

~~That's just how it works.~~

Rohit needs an ally that reaches Aarav directly, and gives Rohit a door to knock on.

## MAGIC TO ROHIT

Aarav plays it alone, privately, and a week later actually asks Rohit a real question, because the app made the topic normal.

## Design implications

- 1 Design for solo, private play on the boy's own device; do not assume a parent in the room.
- 2 Give the parent a separate, optional "how to start the conversation" bridge, not a surveillance dashboard.
- 3 Counter the manosphere-lite directly: emotions are strength, porn is not a manual, respect is the point.
- 4 Earn credibility fast with an older, real tone; never childish, never a lecture.

## OPERATOR &amp; BRIDGE

# Rekha Verma, 39

Homemaker · Bhopal · joint family · daughter Diya, 11

**"When my daughter got her first period, the house taught her it was something to hide. I want her to know it's normal, without starting a fight."**

|           |                                                                      |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HOME      | Joint family: husband, his parents, Diya (11) and a younger son.     |
| LANGUAGES | Hindi at home; English-medium school; Diya reads both.               |
| DEVICES   | One shared Android; Diya gets supervised slots.                      |
| CARE      | Local school runs a once-a-year "health" talk, boys and girls split. |
| MONEY     | Single income; careful.                                              |

**The week it started.** Diya was handed a cloth and a list of don'ts: don't enter the kitchen, don't go to the temple, don't tell your brother, don't make a fuss. Rekha remembers her own shame and wants better for her daughter, but dadi runs the house and "that is how it has always been". Rekha needs Diya to get the facts and the dignity, delivered so the elders do not feel attacked.

## What she wants

- Accurate, calm period and puberty information for Diya, in private.
- Framing that the elders can tolerate, ideally even approve of.
- Her son to learn periods are normal too, not a girls' secret.
- Diya to keep her confidence through a shaming season.

## The bias in the room

Menstruation as impurity and secret; restriction framed as protection; a girl's body as a source of shame the moment it changes.

**Periods are dirty.**

**Don't tell the boys.**

Rekha wins when the product makes "normal and healthy" feel respectful, not rebellious.

## Why she'd bounce

- Content that openly mocks tradition; it will be banned at home.
- English-only material the grandmother cannot check.
- Anything that makes Diya more visible or teased.

### RISKY TO REKHA

A loud "smash the taboo" game she could never let dadi see Diya playing.

### MAGIC TO REKHA

A calm, private explainer that treats periods as health, that Diya plays alone, and that even her little brother can learn from.

## Design implications

- 1 Treat menstruation and puberty as plain health and hygiene; shame-free, never preachy or anti-elder.
- 2 Make it gender-inclusive: boys learn about periods too, so it stops being a hidden "girls' thing".
- 3 Ship bilingual, with a private solo mode a girl can use without an audience.
- 4 Offer a quiet parent note that frames the topic for a conservative household.

## OPERATOR UNDER PRESSURE

## Lakshmi Devi, 34

Domestic worker · peri-urban · daughter Priya, 12 (Class 7, government school)

**"People look at her differently now. I worry about her safety, and I worry she'll stop going to school like the other girls did."**

|           |                                                                              |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HOME      | Two rooms; husband and Lakshmi both work long hours; Priya and two siblings. |
| LANGUAGES | Telugu / Hindi; little English; Lakshmi reads slowly.                        |
| DEVICES   | One shared phone; pads are a stretch on the budget.                          |
| CARE      | Government school; an ASHA worker and an NGO visit occasionally.             |
| MONEY     | Daily-wage; period products compete with food.                               |

**This term.** Since Priya started her period she has missed school several days a month, there is no clean toilet or spare pad there, and relatives have started hinting she should "be careful" and not roam. Lakshmi's instinct, born of fear, is to keep her home and close. She does not want Priya to become another girl who quietly drops out at twelve, but she does not know how to prevent it.

## What she wants

- Priya safe, in school, and not ashamed of her own body.
- Practical, free information she and Priya can both understand.
- Something that works on the shared phone, offline, in their language.
- Reassurance that keeping Priya in school is the safer choice.

## Why she'd bounce

- Text-heavy or English-only; neither of them can use it.
- Data-hungry or online-only; the pack won't allow it.
- Anything that feels shaming or "not for people like us".

## USELESS TO LAKSHMI

A glossy online app in English. It does not exist for this phone or this household.

## The bias she carries

Protection through restriction; a developing girl as a risk to manage; safety defined as staying home, not as knowledge and confidence.

**A grown girl shouldn't roam.**

**Periods mean staying home.**

She is not the obstacle; she is unserved and afraid. Dignity-first, audio-first design reaches her.

## MAGIC TO LAKSHMI

An offline, spoken, local-language guide on managing periods with dignity, and a clear message that school is where Priya belongs.

## Design implications

- 1 Audio-first, local-language, offline, on a budget phone; never gate facts behind reading or data.
- 2 Carry practical menstrual-hygiene and low-cost coping content, not just concepts.
- 3 Frame safety as knowledge and staying in school, the opposite of restriction.
- 4 Plug into the real delivery channels: ASHA, NGO and the school health programme.

## THE LEARNER

# Aarav, 12

Metro · withdrawn, online · "the one the feed got to first"

"I already know all this. Everyone does. Can I go back to my game?"

## Where he is, developmentally

- Early puberty: voice, height, comparison, self-consciousness; wants privacy and control.
- Lives in gaming and voice chat; fluent in stream and meme culture.
- Taught by the feed that feelings are weakness and dominance is status.
- Curious about sex and bodies; getting his answers from porn and friends.
- Pulling away from parents; peers and creators are the authority.

### INSTANTLY CLOSED BY AARAV

A cartoonish "let's learn about your body!" app. Cringe. Back to the game in three seconds.

**What's reaching him.** Aarav is not a problem child; he is a normal twelve-year-old whose questions are being answered by the worst available sources. He acts like he knows everything because admitting he doesn't feels unsafe. Reach him in private, treat him as capable, and the bravado drops fast.

### MAGIC TO AARAV

Something private and a bit grown-up that answers what he was too proud to ask, and quietly dismantles the "be a man" script he's been fed.

## Design implications

- 1 Private and judgment-free: let him explore the embarrassing questions with nobody watching.
- 2 Respect his intelligence; drop the cartoon register, match the credibility of his feed.
- 3 Take on porn-as-manual and "alpha" myths with calm facts, not panic.
- 4 Make emotional literacy feel like strength and skill, not a soft lecture.

## THE LEARNER

# Diya, 11

Tier-2 · newly menstruating · "the one too embarrassed to ask"

**"I didn't know what was happening. I was too scared to ask Mummy, so I searched it on the phone."**

## Where she is, developmentally

- Puberty underway: periods, body changes, sharp new self-consciousness.
- Bilingual reader; capable, careful, eager to do things "right".
- Mortified to discuss her body with parents or in a shared house.
- Compares herself to classmates; fears being teased about developing.
- Turns to the shared phone, in secret, for answers she can't ask for.

### OFF-LIMITS TO DIYA

Anything she'd have to play out loud or near family.  
She will simply never open it.

**What she's absorbing.** Diya is being taught that her changing body is a secret and a problem. She wants facts and reassurance but every channel feels unsafe: parents are embarrassing, the house is watching, the internet is a gamble. A private, accurate, kind source is exactly the gap in her life.

### MAGIC TO DIYA

A private, gentle guide that answers "is this normal?" honestly, in her language, with nobody able to see her screen.

## Design implications

- 1 Private by default: discreet entry, no audio required, nothing that announces what she's reading.
- 2 Answer "is this normal?" plainly and warmly; normalise every common change.
- 3 Bilingual and calm; reassurance over drills.
- 4 Build body confidence against teasing, not just biology facts.

## THE LEARNER

# Priya, 12

Low-income · resourceful · "the one teaching herself"

**"When I have my period I miss school. At home, the phone tells me the things no one will."**

## Where she is

- Puberty plus real-world stakes: missed school, restriction, a dropout shadow.
- Sharp and self-directed; learns from the shared phone whenever she can.
- Reads slowly in English; fluent and curious in her home language.
- Carries shame the world put on her, and a quiet determination.
- Her trusted adults are a teacher, an ASHA worker, an NGO didi, not her busy parents.

### OUT OF REACH FOR PRIYA

An online, English, data-hungry app. It assumes a life she doesn't have.

**What she's up against.** Priya is exactly the girl the statistics are about, and exactly the girl who stays in school when she gets information, dignity and a reason. She does not need pity; she needs a private, offline, spoken source that treats her as capable and keeps her learning between the gaps in her day.

### MAGIC TO PRIYA

An offline, spoken, local-language guide she can use alone, that respects her, and that tells her her body is not a reason to disappear.

## Design implications

- 1 Offline, audio-first, local-language; usable in stolen minutes on a shared phone.
- 2 Dignity over pity: treat her as capable and self-directed, not a victim.
- 3 Tie knowledge to staying in school and to safe, trusted adults she actually has.
- 4 Keep sessions short and complete, for a life with few uninterrupted windows.

## FACILITATOR

# Mr. Khanna, 38

Class 6-7 science / health teacher · government-aided school · the AEP messenger

**"I'm told to teach the adolescence module, and I'm told by parents not to. I need something credible that covers me."**

## His reality

- Tasked with the Adolescence Education Programme and school health sessions.
- Faces parent suspicion, his own discomfort, and a class of squirming 11-year-olds.
- Often splits boys and girls for "that" session; little usable material.
- Exam pressure means almost no curricular time, and no margin for controversy.

### UNUSABLE TO HIM

Edgy or opinion-led content. One offended parent and the whole programme is shut down.

**What he needs from SwipeEd.** Accurate, neutral, government-aligned content he can run on the class screen or assign privately, framed so it survives a parent complaint. A way to handle puberty and safety with a mixed or split class without it descending into giggles or a scandal. Something that makes him the credible adult, not the cause of an awkward PTA meeting.

### MAGIC TO HIM

A calm, fact-based module aligned to the national health curriculum, with a "why this is safe to teach" note and a private-play option for sensitive parts.

## Design implications

- 1 Align visibly to AEP / Ayushman Bharat school-health content; neutral and fact-based.
- 2 Give him cover: a parent-facing rationale and a "safe to teach" framing for each sensitive node.
- 3 Support both group delivery and private individual play for the embarrassing parts.
- 4 Fit tiny curricular slots; zero prep; works split-class or whole-class.

## NEAR-PEER FACILITATOR

## Asha, 24

RKSK peer educator / NGO field worker · the one the kids actually trust

**"They won't tell their parents or teachers. They tell me, because I'm close enough to remember and far enough to be safe."**

## Her reality

- Runs adolescent-health sessions in low-income schools and communities.
- Trusted precisely because she is young and not an authority figure.
- Deals daily with period poverty, dropout risk, early-marriage pressure, safety.
- Works multilingual, low-resource, with little parent buy-in.

## WRONG FOR HER

A stiff, authoritative, English app. It breaks the exact trust her whole role depends on.

**What she needs from SwipeEd.** A near-peer-voiced, multilingual, offline toolkit she can run with a group or hand to a girl privately, covering the things kids are too ashamed to raise. Content that matches the trusted, non-judgmental register she has built, so the app extends her reach instead of sounding like the adults the kids tuned out.

## MAGIC TO ASHA

An offline, local-language kit in a warm near-peer voice, that a girl can also take home and use alone after the session ends.

## Design implications

- 1 Voice it as a trusted near-peer (this is who Lensy becomes for 9-12), never an authority.
- 2 Offline, multilingual, low-resource; group-led and take-home-private in one.
- 3 Cover the hard realities: period poverty, dropout, safety, with practical help.
- 4 Route to real support and trusted adults; make help-seeking the move.

# What Chapter 3 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one theme dominates: the adults have lost the room, and the design has to win the trust they're losing, privately, accurately and without shame.

| PRINCIPLE                             | BECAUSE                                                                               | SHOWS UP AS                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Private, solo play</b>             | Embarrassment is the gatekeeper; no pre-teen does a body game with a parent watching. | Discreet entry, no audio needed, no "show a parent" beat on sensitive nodes. |
| <b>Be the trusted source</b>          | The questions they can't ask adults go to search and porn instead.                    | Answer "is this normal?" honestly; a near-peer voice, not an authority.      |
| <b>Never childish, never preachy</b>  | They reject baby tone and lectures equally; the feed is their bar.                    | An older, credible register; Lensy grows up a little.                        |
| <b>Puberty as normal and accurate</b> | Periods, wet dreams, body changes, taught as health, not shame.                       | Shame-free, gender-inclusive facts; boys learn about periods too.            |
| <b>Mind is core content</b>           | Comparison, anxiety and self-esteem now drive the experience.                         | Coping skills, normalising, clear "where to turn".                           |
| <b>Online life is the arena</b>       | Consent, grooming, body image and the manosphere all live online now.                 | Online-safety and media beats; counter "be a man" and porn-as-manual.        |
| <b>Equity and access</b>              | Period poverty and dropout are live risks at exactly this age.                        | Offline, in-language, dignity-first; tied to staying in school.              |
| <b>Cover for the adults</b>           | AEP taboo and joint-family elders can shut the whole thing down.                      | Parent and teacher framing, AEP alignment, gendered-session support.         |

## The same principles, on the nine Chapter 3 games

| GAME                             | THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Puberty Quest</b> (g13)       | Accurate, shame-free, gender-inclusive puberty; private solo play; periods, wet dreams and hygiene with the taboo removed. |
| <b>Mind Matters</b> (g38)        | Mental health as core: comparison, anxiety, coping, and a clear, safe "where to turn".                                     |
| <b>The Amazing Journey</b> (g14) | Reproduction as science, family- and school-safe, replacing playground and porn rumours; AEP-aligned framing.              |
| <b>Boundary Bot</b> (g15)        | Consent and boundaries online: grooming, sharing photos, saying no to peers and adults alike.                              |
| <b>Crossroads</b> (g16)          | Early crushes and peer pressure; the first seeds of "jealousy isn't love"; choices, not labels.                            |
| <b>Flip the Script</b> (g17)     | Counter the manosphere-lite: boys can feel, girls can lead; dismantle "be a man".                                          |

|                                    |                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Norm Storm</b> (g18)            | Question the restrictions Diya and Priya face; "is this fair?" against tradition, respectfully.         |
| <b>Speak Up</b> (g19)              | Bystander and reporting for body-shaming and period-teasing; route to a trusted adult or peer educator. |
| <b>Defenders of the Body</b> (g20) | Health, hygiene and prevention, including menstrual hygiene, handled practically and without shame.     |

Next: the same persona lens for Chapters 4-8, or a Chapter 3 game-by-game redesign built on this brief.